

Handout 6: How to C.R.E.A.T.E a supervision environment for Peer Specialist success

Peer support supervision is like other types of supervision in many ways. However, there are unique considerations when structuring and approaching a supervision check-in with Peer Specialists. The **C.R.E.A.T.E.** format below is offered as a supportive and recovery-oriented approach to supervision.

Connect

Strive to build an intentional and focused connection with the Peer Specialist. Help them see this is their time. Honor this opportunity to connect by eliminating distractions (phone, email, off-topic subjects, etc.). Practice active listening to demonstrate a commitment to hearing and understanding what the Peer Specialist shares.

Recognize

Look for opportunities to point out and celebrate achievements and successes. Did the Peer Specialist advocate for a peer's needs in a recent team meeting? If so, mention this as a strong demonstration of advocacy. Build a strengths-based environment that looks for what's strong!

Encourage

Allow the Peer Specialist to share any challenges they encountered in their work since your last check-in. Have they experienced any challenges in supporting their peers? Do they feel "stuck" or unsure about how to best offer peer support? Do they have any concerns about the well-being or safety of their peers? Create an environment of safety and trust that encourages the Peer Specialist to feel comfortable in sharing challenges and brainstorming solutions.

Acknowledge

Look for opportunities to acknowledge how the Peer Specialist is taking the initiative in their work, making recovery-oriented and peer-focused decisions, and demonstrating leadership and advocacy. As their supervisor, you are in a unique position to celebrate their

skills and successes. Doing so in a team environment, if the Peer Specialist is comfortable with the recognition, also sends a powerful message about their contributions and their unique role in overall service delivery.

Train

The world of peer support services and best practices for delivering them is constantly evolving. Regularly ask the Peer Specialist if there are trainings they would like to attend, specific skills they would like to learn, resources they would find helpful, or practical tools they need help with to offer the best Peer Support possible. This might include peer support webinars and recognized recovery and support methods such as the Wellness Recovery Action Plan (WRAP), Intentional Peer Support (IPS), and Emotional CPR (eCPR), to name a few.

Does the Peer Specialist feel confident and equipped to successfully use your electronic health record (EHR) system? As their supervisor, you have a unique opportunity and responsibility to support them in feeling confident in all aspects of their work.

Empower

Regularly find out if the Peer Specialist feels they have everything they need to do their job. Suppose the Peer Specialist has a busy peer support schedule. Are you encouraging on-the-clock time for them to complete documentation? If the Peer Specialist is required to transport their peers are agency vehicles available? Is the Peer Specialist facilitating peer support groups? If so, do they

have any needed material such as manuals, worksheets, poster paper, etc.? Does the Peer Specialist have scheduled access to a meeting room?

Empowering Peer Specialists with what they need to do the work sends a powerful message that recognizes the importance and value of the role and the unique support they provide.

Remember: Peer Specialist supervision is about the person first, and then about supporting the actions they take to offer the best peer support services possible to achieve peer-driven recovery and wellness goals.

C.R.E.A.T.E Peer Specialist Supervision form

C.R.E.A.T.E.: Connect, Recognize, Encourage, Acknowledge, Train, Empower

Supervision participants and meeting deadlines

Peer Specialist's name: _____

Supervisor's name: _____

Mode of supervision

- ☐ In-person
- ☐ Online
- ☐ Phone call

Date and duration of supervision meeting: _____

Description and documentation of topics discussed

Connect: As the supervisor, did you strive to focus, minimize distractions, and actively listen?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Recognize: Success, achievements, etc.

Encourage: Challenges, difficulties, etc.

Acknowledge: Initiative, leadership, advocacy, etc.

Train: Learning opportunities, classes, webinars, comfort level with agency processes, etc.

Empower: Adequate time for documentation, peer transportation, meeting materials, etc.

C.R.E.A.T.E. action plan for implementation of discussed topics:

Peer Specialist's signature: _____ **Date:** _____

Supervisor's signature: _____ **Date:** _____